Usability & User Experience

Web Design – Lecture 2

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Recap

- Last time:
  - Web design = technology + design + human behaviour
  - The web design process is iterative
  - Core principles: clarity, consistency, visual hierarchy, accessibility

- **Today:** Understanding the user

Agenda

1. Usability
2. User experience
3. Usability testing
4. Activity

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Part 1

Usability

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What is Usability?

Can people actually use your website?

- ISO 9241 definition:

  "The extent to which a product can be used by specified users to achieve specified goals with **effectiveness**, **efficiency**, and **satisfaction**."

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The Three Components

- **Effectiveness**
  - Can users complete their tasks successfully?
- **Efficiency**
  - How quickly can they do it?
- **Satisfaction**
  - How do they feel about the experience?

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Usability vs Usefulness

- **Usefulness:** Does the product do something people need?
- **Usability:** Can people figure out how to use it?

- A product can be useful but unusable.
- A product can be usable but useless.

- You need both.

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Jakob Nielsen

- Pioneer of web usability
- Co-founded Nielsen Norman Group

- Created the **10 Usability Heuristics** in 1994
- Still relevant 30 years later!

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10 usability heuristics

#1: visibility of system status

Keep users informed about what's going on

- Examples:
  - Loading indicators
  - Progress bars
  - “Your message has been sent”
  - Highlighting the current page in navigation

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10 usability heuristics

#2: match between system & real world

Speak the user's language

- Use words and concepts users know
- Avoid technical jargon
- Follow real-world conventions
- Information in natural, logical order

10 usability heuristics
#3: user control & freedom

Provide an emergency exit

- Users make mistakes. Let them:
  - Undo actions
  - Cancel processes
  - Go back easily
  - Close dialogs

- "Are you sure?" is not enough.

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#4: consistency & standards

Don't make users wonder

- Same words = same things
- Same actions = same results
- Follow platform conventions
- Internal consistency across your site

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10 usability heuristics

#5: error prevention

Better than good error messages: prevent errors

- Disable buttons when actions aren't available
- Use constraints (date pickers vs text fields)
- Confirm destructive actions
- Provide sensible defaults

10 usability heuristics

#6: recognition rather than recall

Don't force users to remember

- Show options, don't require typing
- Make information visible or easily retrievable
- Provide context
- Use familiar patterns

10 usability heuristics
#7: flexibility & efficiency

Cater to both novices and experts

- Shortcuts for experienced users
- Allow customisation
- Let users tailor frequent actions
- Support different paths to the same goal

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10 usability heuristics
#8: aesthetic & minimalist design

Less is more

- Every extra element competes for attention
- Remove what doesn't serve a purpose
- Prioritise important information
- White space is your friend

“Good design is as little design as possible” – Dieter Rams

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10 usability heuristics

#9: help users recover from errors

When errors happen (they will):

- Error messages in plain language
- Precisely indicate the problem
- Constructively suggest a solution
- Don't blame the user

10 usability heuristics
#10: help & documentation

Ideally not needed, but when it is:

- Easy to search
- Focused on user tasks
- List concrete steps
- Keep it brief

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Common usability problems

Navigation confusion

- “Where am I?”
- “How do I get back?”
- Too many options

Poor feedback

- “Did that work?”
- “Is it loading?”

Overwhelming interfaces

- Too much on screen
- No clear hierarchy

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Part 2

User Experience

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From Usability to UX

- **Usability:**
  - Can they use it?

- **User Experience:**
  - How does the whole experience feel?

- UX is the bigger picture —
  - every touchpoint,
  - every interaction,
  - every feeling.

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Peter Morville's UX honeycomb

Useful — serves a purpose

Usable — easy to use

Findable — easy to navigate

Credible — trustworthy

Accessible — works for everyone

Desirable — creates positive emotions

Valuable — delivers value to user and business

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Understanding users

- You are not your user.
- Your assumptions are often wrong.
- The only way to know users is to **research** them.

User Research Methods

- **Interviews**
  - Talk to users one-on-one
- **Surveys**
  - Gather data at scale
- **Observation**
  - Watch users in their natural environment
- **Analytics**
  - See what users actually do (not what they say)

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Personas

- **A fictional character representing a user group**
- Based on research, not assumptions.
- Includes:
  - Demographics
  - Goals and motivations
  - Pain points and frustrations
  - Behaviours and preferences

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Example persona

Anna, 34

Marketing manager at a small company

- **Goals:** Find information quickly, look professional
- **Frustrations:** Complex tools, too many clicks, slow loading
- **Quote:** "I don't have time to figure this out"

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User Journeys

Map the complete experience:

1. **Awareness** — How do they find you?
2. **Consideration** — What do they evaluate?
3. **Action** — What do they do?
4. **Retention** — Do they come back?
5. **Advocacy** — Do they recommend you?

Emotional design

Don Norman's Three Levels:

- **Visceral** — Immediate, instinctive reaction
  "Wow, this looks great!"
- **Behavioural** — The experience of use
  "This is easy and pleasant to use"
- **Reflective** — Long-term impression
  "I love this product; it says something about me"

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First impressions matter

- Users form opinions in **50 milliseconds**

- Before they read anything, they've judged:
  - Visual appeal
  - Credibility
  - Whether to stay or leave

- Design for that first half-second.

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Trust signals

What makes a website trustworthy?

- Professional design
- Clear contact information
- Security indicators (HTTPS, padlock)
- Social proof (reviews, testimonials)
- No spelling errors
- Fast performance

Delight

- **Going beyond usability:**
  - Micro-interactions
  - Thoughtful animations
  - Personality in copy
  - Unexpected moments of joy

- Delight comes after usability, not instead of it.

The role of empathy

- **Good UX requires understanding**
  - What are users trying to accomplish?
  - What frustrates them?
  - What context are they in?
  - What are their constraints?

- Put yourself in their shoes.

Balancing needs

- **Users want:**
  - Quick, easy experience
  - Free, no ads
  - Privacy

- **Business wants:**
  - Engagement, conversions
  - Revenue
  - Data

- Good UX finds the balance.

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Iterative design

- **Never “done”:**
  - Research
  - Design
  - Build
  - Test
  - Learn
  - Repeat

- Every iteration should improve the experience.

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Part 3

Usability testing

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Usability testing

- **Watch real users try to use your product**

- The most valuable feedback comes from observing behaviour, not asking opinions.
- "What people say" ≠ "What people do"

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Why test?

- Discover problems you're blind to
- Validate (or invalidate) your assumptions
- Prioritise what to fix
- Build confidence before launch

- **You only need 5 users** to find most usability problems (Nielsen)

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Think-Aloud testing

- **The simplest usability test**
  1. Give the user a task
  2. Ask them to verbalise their thoughts
  3. Watch and listen — don't help!
  4. Take notes

- *“Find the opening hours for this café”*

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Hallway testing

- **Grab someone walking by and ask them to try your site**
  - Takes 5 minutes
  - No recruitment, no planning
  - Anyone is better than no one
  - Do it early and often
- The name comes from literally stopping people in the hallway.
- Perfect for quick feedback during development.

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What to look for

- Where do users hesitate or get confused?
- What do they click that doesn't work?
- What do they miss entirely?
- What do they say vs. what do they do?
- How do they describe things?

Running a test

Dos

- ✓ Test early, even with sketches or prototypes
- ✓ Use realistic tasks, not instructions
- ✓ Stay quiet — let them struggle
- ✓ Ask follow-up questions: *"What did you expect?"*
- ✓ Thank them — there are no wrong answers

Don'ts

- ¤ Don't explain or help during the task
- ¤ Don't defend your design
- ¤ Don't ask leading questions
- ¤ Don't test with friends or colleagues (if possible)
- ¤ Don't wait until the end to test

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Other testing methods

- **A/B Testing**
  - Compare two versions with real traffic
- **Card Sorting**
  - Understand how users categorise information
- **First-Click Testing**
  - Where do users click first?
- **Accessibility Testing**
  - Test with screen readers, keyboard-only navigation

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Heuristic evaluation

- **Expert review using established principles**
  - Cheap and fast
  - No users required
  - Good for finding obvious problems
  - Best combined with user testing

- We'll practise this now.

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Part 4

Heuristic evaluation activity

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Activity
Heuristic evaluation

In pairs or small groups:

1. Choose *one* website, e.g. one of these:
   - ryanair.com
   - booking.com
   - wish.com
   - shein.com
2. Spend 10-15 minutes exploring it as a real user
   - Perform a real task as a user would
3. Evaluate against Nielsen's 10 heuristics
4. Find at least 3 usability problems
5. Suggest improvements

Time: 20 minutes

1. Visibility of System Status
2. Match Between the System and the Real World
3. User Control and Freedom
4. Consistency and Standards
5. Error Prevention
6. Recognition Rather than Recall
7. Flexibility and Efficiency of Use
8. Aesthetic and Minimalist Design
9. Help Users Recognize, Diagnose, and Recover from Errors
10. Help and Documentation

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Activity
Discussion

- What did you find?

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Part 5

Conclusion

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Key takeaways

- Usability = effectiveness + efficiency + satisfaction
- Nielsen's heuristics are a powerful evaluation tool
- UX encompasses the entire user experience
- Research your users — don't assume
- Design iteratively, test continuously

Looking ahead

Next lecture: HTML & Structured Content

- The foundation of every web page
- Semantic HTML
- Content-first design

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Questions?

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